



Cover story **BARACK OBAMA**

ambassador to the US, who had braved the chilly winds to witness the oath-taking ceremony on the steps of Capitol Hill in Washington DC, believed that the larger message that Obama conveyed was "a sense of American renewal, a unity of purpose and the end to cynicism that had gripped the nation in recent times".

Compared to the soaring rhetoric of his campaign speeches, Obama was somber in keeping with the exceptional crisis that the US finds itself in. With America's troops locked in two debilitating wars, its economy badly shaken and weakened by a deepening financial crisis and the nation's confidence severely dented, the new President knew that wherever he looked "there is work to be done" and called for "action, bold and swift". For India, Obama's presidency will be, as Sen says, "a whole new ball game".

HOW IS HE DIFFERENT FROM BUSH?

If you go by the construct of the past, then US presidents, who are Democrats, are not usually good news for India. They rarely lived up to their promise. John F. Kennedy brought the hope of change. But in India's critical hour during the invasion by China, he failed to come to New Delhi's aid. Jimmy Carter, despite his infectious smile and professed goodwill for India, delivered "a cold and blunt message" to the then prime minister Morarji Desai over India's nuclear ambitions in 1978. Bill Clinton was indifferent to India till the 1998 nuclear tests and then his administration went ballistic against the government headed by Atal Bihari Vajpayee. By the time Clinton paid his first visit to India in 2000, it was too little and too late even though he succeeded in charming the nation.

In comparison, Republican presidents such as Dwight Eisenhower, Ronald Reagan and

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more recently, George W. Bush, played a significant role in cementing relations with India. Eisenhower became the first US president to visit India in 1959 and was bowled over by the warmth of the reception. Reagan broke the logjam over India's nuclear stance and opened whole new avenues for trade, including in hi-tech.

Bush, though, will go down in recent history as the President who did the most to transform relations between the two nations by putting his weight behind the path-breaking Indo-US nuclear deal. Prime Minister Manmohan

Singh even went to the extent of describing Bush "as the friendliest of US Presidents." The exceptions among Republicans were Richard Nixon—whose personal animosity towards Indira Gandhi affected relations between the two countries—and surprisingly George Bush Sr who was more preoccupied with the first Iraq war and did his worst to curb India's nuclear weapons programme.

His son though was convinced that India was a strategic partner and a natural ally of the US and would come up with a bold solution to transform relations be-